

Communication

Introduction

Communication is a requirement for survival and growth not only of people but also organizations. In the past, nations rose and fell depending on their ability to communicate effectively. History is replete with stories of individuals who became successful because of their effective management of communication. When ancient Rome became the target of hostile forces, its communication system was effective enough to warn its leaders about the forthcoming danger.

Modern armies consider communication as an important factor in waging a successful attempt to defeat the enemy. In the same manner, modern organizations consider communication as an important factor in motivating their employees to improve productivity and to meet competition.

WHAT IS COMMUNICATION

Communication may be defined as the transfer of information including feelings, and ideas, from one person to another. The goal of communication is to have the receiver understand the message as it was intended. The transfer process, however, is affected by a number of factors that either help or hinder the message.

THE IMPORTANCE OF COMMUNICATION

Without communication, organizations cannot exist. It is through communication that the individual members of the organization will know important concerns such as:

1. what their organization is
2. what objectives their organization wants to achieve
3. what their roles are in achieving the organization's objectives
4. how they will achieve those objectives
5. who the individual members of the organization are

The foregoing list is only a partial enumeration of what needs to be communicated to the various personalities involved in operating the organization. It is also through communication that the organization can relate with its external environment which include customers, suppliers, competitors and the government.

Communication is essential for the coordination of business, A must be made effective, if the organization is to be effective. An effective communication system provides management with answers to questions related to what motivates its workers to perform effectively, what products or services the customers want, what products or services the suppliers are providing, and many others.

THE COMMUNICATION PROCESS

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Communication is a two-way process in which a sender reaches a receiver with a message. There is a need for people in organizations to have knowledge of the communication process, and it is the first step to make it effective. There are six components of an effective communication. They are the following:

1. a communication source or sender
2. a message
3. a channel
4. a receiver
5. feedback
6. the environment

The Sender

A communication source or sender is a person who makes the attempt to send a message which could be spoken, written, in sign language, or nonverbal to another person or a group of persons. The degree of attention the message will receive will depend on the perceived authority and experience of a sender. An illustration is provided as follows:

The company clerk cracked a joke in a gathering of employees. To his dismay, nobody reacted. In another occasion, the same joke was used by the president to impress his subordinates in his opening speech. Everybody contributed his share in the general laughter that followed. The clerk who was also present did not know what to say.

The Message

The message is a purpose or an idea to be conveyed in a communication event. The message is the actual physical product as a result of encoding. Thus, when speaking, the speech is the message; when writing, the written document is the message; when making gestures, the movements of the arms and the expressions on faces are the message.

How the message is received is influenced by the following factors:

1. clarity of the message
2. alertness of the receiver
3. complexity and length of the message
4. how the information is organized

A message written or spoken in a language nobody understands will not pass the criteria for clarity. Of course, the message will not be received properly.

When the receiver is busy doing something else like listening to music, he will not be able to understand clearly what the person is relating to him in the story.

To a 12-year old child who has never gone to school, the stock market will be too complex for him and he will not appreciate anything said about it.

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When the information sent to a receiver is not organized, it will be hard for the receiver to fully appreciate it. The following is an example of information that is not well organized:

The company hired 10 people in 2008; 15 employees were fired in 2009; 26 employees were suspended in 2006; and 30 employees were reprimanded in 2008.

The message has two components:

1. The thought or conceptual component of the message - this is contained in the words, ideas, symbols, and concepts chosen to relay the message; and
2. The feeling or emotional component of the message - this is contained in the intensity, force, demeanor, and sometimes the gesture of the communicator or sender. This second component enriches and clarifies the message and its effect is to give the message its full meaning.

The Channel

The channel is the medium through which the message travels. It consists of various types which are as follows:

1. face-to-face
2. telephone and cell phones
3. e-mail
4. written memos and letters
4. posted notices
5. bulletins

In general, the face-to-face channel is the most effective. The least effective are posted notices and bulletins.

Communication channels may be classified also as: (1) formal; and (2) informal. The communication of policies, procedures, and other official announcements properly belong to the formal channel because it is the one recognized as authoritative. Informal channels do not follow the chain of command. Because this is so, people can get in contact with each other at a faster pace.

The grapevine is a type of informal channel that transfer information through networks of friendships and acquaintances. Grapevines have the advantage of being able to transmit information quickly and efficiently. The disadvantage is that it can transmit incorrect or untimely information.

The Receiver

The person receiving a message is the receiver. He must interpret and understand the message. In doing so, however, he will be influenced by factors like his age, gender, beliefs, past experiences, cultural influences, and his individual needs.

The Feedback

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Feedback refers to the process of communicating how one feels about something another person has done or said. When a supervisor calls his subordinates over the phone and asks "how are you getting along with our new recruits?" the answer, which is actually a feedback, could be "I think we made a mistake in recruiting these people."

It is difficult to know whether the message was received and understood without feedback. A feedback provides a clue to the sender of information whether the message he sent was received as intended.

The Environment

The environment refers to the circumstances in which messages are transmitted and received. In an environment of trust and confidence, messages are easily transmitted even if these messages are controversial. The advantage of this type of environment is that management is provided with the opportunity to address a problem before it develops into a full-blown concern.

The Noise

Noise refers to anything that disrupts communication, including the attitude and emotions of the receiver. Noise includes loud music, the feeling about a sick relative, children playing in the background, and many others.

BASIC METHODS OF INTERPERSONAL COMMUNICATION

People in organizations transfer meaning between and each other using any or all of the three basic methods which consist among of the following:

1. verbal
2. written
3. nonverbal communication

Verbal Communication

Verbal communication is a major means of sending messages. It includes one-on-one meetings, speeches, grapevine, telephone, departmental or interdepartmental meetings, presentation, and the like.

The delivery of verbal communication is quick and it provides the opportunity for a quick feedback. With feedbacks, early correction of errors is made possible.

A major disadvantage of verbal is the distortion of the message when it passes to several people. This is because people have their own peculiar way of interpreting messages and this causes distortion of the original message:

Verbal communication is the appropriate method if the sender:

1. wants to appear informal;
2. wants to invite suggestions and ideas which are more likely to spark off a discussion;
3. is explaining something complex and people might need to ask for clarification as he goes along;

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4. has important news to impact, such as retrenchment;
5. needs to be very diplomatic and feels he will be more effective face-to-face than in writing, and
6. has something highly confidential to say and putting it in writing is risky.

Verbal communication is not appropriate when the sender:

1. wants to maintain formality or distance from the other person or a group of people;
2. wants a permanent record of what has been said;
3. needs receiver's comments to be in writing for legal reasons, and
4. wants to avoid further discussion of the subject by signaling that the matter is closed.

Written Communication

Written communication includes memos, notice-boards, and letters to staff, emails, faxes, internal newspaper, and instant messaging

The advantages of written communication are the following:

1. it is formal and authoritative;
2. it provides a permanent record of what have been said;
3. it provides a document useful for legal purposes;
4. a number of people will receive exactly the same information;
5. it is useful in communicating something complicated;
6. it is sometimes quicker (e.g., fax is faster than a phone call);
7. it avoids a lengthy discussion; and
8. words can be chosen carefully.

Written communication is not appropriate when:

1. the receiver needs to ask question or seek clarification;
2. more discussion is needed before facts are established;
3. a friendly and informal atmosphere is needed;
4. the message is very important;
5. the message is confidential; and
6. the information may be upsetting to the receiver.

Nonverbal Communication

Communication that takes place through facial expressions, body movements, eye contact, and other physical gesture is referred to as nonverbal communication. This type of communication reveals what the sender really means or thinking. For example, when we see a person inside a restaurant taking his meal and we noticed that his eyes are gleaming, we can safely presume that he is enjoying what he is eating.

When linked with spoken language, body movements (or more popular, body language) give fuller meaning to a sender's message. For instance, a spoken "goodbye" without a hand waving will be interpreted differently than one with a hand wave.

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One should observe nonverbal cues when a person is delivering a message. It may save the receiver a lot of time and effort. Below shows commonly accepted interpretations of various forms of body language.

COMMONLY ACCEPTED INTERPRETTIONS OF VARIOS FORMS BODY LANGUAGE

Body Language	Interpretation
FACIAL EXPRESSIONS frown smile raised eyebrows narrowed eyes, pursed lips	Displeasure, unhappiness friendliness, happiness Disbelief, amazement Anger
EYE CONTACT glancing steady	interest active listening, interest seduction,
GESTURE pointing finger folded arms authority arms at side hands uplifted outward	authority, displeasure, lecturing not open to change preparing to speak open to suggestions, relaxed disbelief, puzzlement, uncertainty
BODY POSTURES fidgeting, doodling hands on hips shrugging shoulders squared stance of shoulders biting lips, shifting, Jingling money	boredom anger, defensiveness indifference problem solving concerned, listening nervousness

FUNCTIONS OF COMMUNICATION

Communication serves four major functions within a group or organization. These functions consist of the following:

1. Information function - communication provides information needed in decision making. For example, a machine operator's job is to produce a certain number of units of a product given a certain quantity of supplies and materials. Before he proceeds on requisitioning the necessary materials and supplies, he needs to know the quantity of finished products his supervisor wants him to produce. An effective communication system will provide him with the required information.
2. Motivation function - communication is a means used to encourage commitment to organizational objectives. Commitment will not be possible if the worker concerned does not have full appreciation of the advantages of the organization that achieves its goals. The right communication efforts will be

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very useful in this instance. For example, a newly established competitor poses a direct and serious threat to the company. When this is relayed to the workers, they may just consider making some extra efforts to help the company,

3. Control function communication clarifies duties, authority, and responsibilities, thereby permitting control. If, through effective communication, the worker is informed on what exactly he is expected to do, that information alone is enough for the worker to check if he is performing as expected. This will also make it easy for management to pinpoint deviations from what is expected from the worker.
4. Emotive function - communication permits the expression of feelings and the satisfaction of social needs. Workers are human beings and they have a need to express their feelings one way or another. Communication can help them fulfill this need. For example, a female worker cannot concentrate on her work because a male co-worker is exhibiting aggressive and objectionable behavior. When she informed the erring co-worker that she does not like what he is doing and she will not hesitate to report him, the harassment stopped. Then she started feeling good enough to perform well in her job.

BASIC GOALS OF EFFECTIVE COMMUNICATION

Communication is not just about transferring message from one effective. Being effective, however, is not an end but rather a means offers on to another. In organizations, communication must be made to an end. Effective communication is really a way to achieve certain goals which consist of the following:

1. to gain goodwill
2. to inquire
3. to inform
4. to persuade

It can be expected that when communication goals are achieved, accomplishing the organizational objectives will be a matter of course.

BARRIERS TO COMMUNICATION

There are times when the receiver is not able to properly receive or understand the message as intended by the sender. This is due to a variety of barriers that may impede the communication effort. These barriers consist of the following:

1. filtering
2. selective perception
3. information overload
4. emotions
5. language
6. communication apprehension
7. absence of feedback
8. physical separation
9. lack of credibility of the sender

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Filtering

Filtering refers to the manipulation of information so that it will be seen more favorably by the receiver. Telling what the boss wants to hear is filtering.

Subordinates filter information to avoid displeasing their superiors, such as when reporting the increasing number of employee turnover. Sometimes, filtering is used to promote one's interests in the organization. Filtering can be neutralized if the superior uses other channels of communication like the grapevine.

Selective Perception

Receivers selectively see and hear messages based on their needs, motivations, experience, background, and other personal characteristics. For instance, a person who has limited exposure to recruitment will find it difficult to actively listen to a lecture on current hiring practices.

People have different perception of reality; what they see is what they call reality. What the eyes say as reality is regarded as reality. This is so even if they do not see perfectly clear. A color blind person sees everything dark as black; he sees dark blue as black; and to him that is reality. A tone-deaf person cannot distinguish the difference between the musical tones "do, re, mi..." To him all tones sound the same; and to him that reality. No amount of explanation will convince him that "do" sounds differently from "re".

Information Overload

Information overload refers to the condition in which information inflow exceeds an individual's processing capacity. When this happens, the person is no longer able to understand clearly whatever information is sent to him.

Emotions

The receiver's feelings affect his ability to understand any message sent to him. He cannot receive a message as clearly as when he is not angry, excited, or afraid. For instance, when a person is stricken with grief, it cannot be expected that he will be able to absorb the details of a project presented to him.

Language

Words do not always mean the same thing to different people. This poses a barrier to communication. Although the words "lavatory", "john", "toilet", and "restroom" mean the same, the word comfort room or CR is the one more readily understood by many Filipinos.

The best thing to do when delivering a message is that the sender must use words that are commonly used by the audience. This will facilitate communication.

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Communication Apprehension

Communication apprehension refers to the undue tension and anxiety about oral communication, written communication, or both. There are people who find it extremely difficult to talk with others face-to-face or even carry a telephone conversation.

To compensate, they try to find other means to communicate which oftentimes are less effective and more time consuming.

Absence of Feedback

Feedback is an essential component of effective communication. When feedback is received by the sender, he can make some clarification if he thinks the receiver did not clearly understand what the sender means.

The absence of feedback does not provide the sender the opportunity to correct misimpressions about the message sent. Also, without feedback, the sender will not know if the message was received at all.

Physical Separation

Physical separation refers to interferences to effective communication occurring in the environment where the communication is undertaken. These are actually physical barriers which include the following:

1. distances between people;
2. walls;
3. an office that is not conducive to communication;
4. an intimidating person posted near the door; or
5. wrong timing

Telephones, cell phones, and e-mail are useful tools in bridging the physical gap, but face-to-face communication is still more effective. This is so because gadgets cannot provide a complete view of the circumstances surrounding the sender and the receiver.

Lack of Credibility of the Sender

Depending on the credibility of the sender, messages can get through the channel to the receiver. If the sender has low credibility, the message, even if it gets through, will likely be ignored. This is a type of barrier that should be overcome by leaders of organizations.

It is not enough that the leaders should be credible. His lieutenants must also be credible, and the leader should make them credible before the eyes of the members of the organization. If by omission or commission, he makes a move that sabotages the credibility of his assistants, it would be tantamount to sabotaging his own credibility efforts.

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KINDS OF COMMUNICATION FLOW

The flow of communication in organization takes different directions. It consists of the following:

1. downward
2. upward; or
3. horizontal

Downward Communication

Downward communication refers to message flows from higher levels to lower levels. Their purposes are:

1. to give instructions;
2. to provide information about policies and procedures;
3. to give feedback about performances; and
4. to indoctrinate or motivate.

The various techniques used in downward communication are:

1. letters, meetings, and the telephone or cell phone;
2. manuals;
3. handbooks; and
4. newsletters.

Upward Communication

Upward communication refers to messages from persons in lower level positions to persons in higher positions. Its purposes are:

1. to provide feedback to higher-ups;
2. to inform higher-ups of progress towards goals; and
3. to relay current problems.

The techniques used in upward communication are:

1. performance reports;
2. suggestion systems;
3. informal gripe sessions;
4. open-door policy; and
5. exit interviews.

Horizontal Communication

Horizontal communication refers to messages sent to individuals or groups from another of the same organizational level or position. Its purposes are:

1. to coordinate activities between departments;
2. to persuade others at the same level of organization; and
3. to pass on information about activities or feelings.

The techniques appropriate for horizontal communication are:

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1. memos;
2. telephones or cell phones,
3. picnics; and
4. dinners and other social affairs.

IMPROVING COMMUNICATION IN ORGANIZATIONS

Ineffective communication can affect people involved in it negatively. It can cause hurt feelings, and waste of time and valuable resources. To avoid such unwanted effects, the following tips could be useful:

1. The message should be improved so it could be easily understood; and
2. The receiver must improve his skill in understanding the 2. messages sent to him.

Summary

Communication is an essential element of organizations. Without communication, organizations cannot exist.

Effective communication consists of six components: the sender, the message, the channel, the receiver, feedback, and the environment. Noise affects the effectivity of communication.

Interpersonal communication may be verbal, written or nonverbal

Communication serves four major functions: information, motivation, control, and emotive, The basic goals of communication are: (1) to gain goodwill; (2) to inquire; (3) to inform; and (4) to persuade,

Communication barriers include filtering, selective perception, information overload, emotions, language, and communication apprehension, absence of feedback, physical separation, and lack of credibility of the sender.

According to flow, communication may be classified as downward, upward, or horizontal, to improve communication, the message must be improved and the skills in receiving messages must also be improved.

Assessment

Answer the following questions in a separate sheet of paper. Submit to your teacher via google classroom email or messenger.

File name should be [Surname/Activity 7/Leadership in Organization]
ex. **Dela Cruz Activity 7 Leadership in Organization**

1. What is communication? How important is it in the organization?
2. What are the components of an effective communication?
3. What are the various types of communication channels?
4. Why is face-to-face communication the most effective? What factors influence the person receiving the message?

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5. What are the basic methods of interpersonal communication?
6. If the sender wants to appear informal, what is the appropriate method of communication?
7. What is nonverbal communication?
8. What are the major functions of communication?
10. What are the basic goals of communication?

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